



PTI PHOTO

SIGNATURE STYLE: Rahul and Sonia in Beijing

who boarded the plane to China. There he signed an MOU with the Communist Party of China. The mother and son also caught up with PPP Chairman Bilawal Bhutto and built on Rajiv Gandhi's rapport with his mother Benazir. The Beijing visit is significant—while other countries sent their heads of state, India sent the head of the Congress party.

Last month, Sonia had announced two new committees comprising Union ministers and party officials to draft the political strategy for the next polls. As a member of the manifesto committee, Rahul will play a key role in Campaign 2009. He may not be the prime ministerial candidate, but he certainly is the pan-Indian star campaigner. For the young scion, it is party time now. **by Priya Sahgal**

Leading from the Front

DELHI The Congress seems to be migrating from the tired and tested pantheon approach to an iconic course for leadership. Suddenly Sonia Gandhi and her son Rahul are leading from the front and visibly so. With Congress strategists toying with the idea of announcing the

general elections a few months early—January instead of March 2009—the Gandhi duo is taking an active interest in place of the usual unseen hand of 10 Janpath's approach.

NCP chief Sharad Pawar may feel that it is too early to comment on Rahul's name for prime

minister but 10 Janpath has begun work on his leadership profile. If the Congress is to be educated about the nuclear question, then Rahul is a key speaker. When the Government had to send a representative to Beijing, it was not Manmohan Singh but Rahul and Sonia

THE BUZZ OF THE WEEK

Which Yadav will have more berths? If the UPA accepts the demand of Samajwadi Party and grants it five cabinet berths, Lalu Prasad Yadav, with just three Cabinet rank ministers, will be deemed the lesser Yadav.

VOICES

“Projecting somebody as the prime ministerial candidate before elections is wrong. We have many capable leaders for the post.”

Sitaram Yechury, CPI(M) Politburo member

“I should visit my father's grave and ask whether staying on in India after the Partition was the right decision. A time has come when I could require a visa to visit Jammu.”

Farooq Abdullah, National Conference patron

“The CPI(M) used to put the brakes on the UPA from acting tough on groups like SIMI. Now the SP is preventing the Centre from acting against religious fundamentalists.”

Murli Manohar Joshi, BJP leader

“I expect...the US representative to the NSG not to seek or support any exemption for India that does not faithfully reflect all of the Hyde Act conditions.”

Howard Berman, chairman, US House Committee on Foreign Affairs

“Money alone cannot do magic. Special efforts also have to be initiated from the grassroots level to identify and promote young talent in the country.”

P.T. Usha, former ace sprinter